HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

# The Ten Uses of Bitahon: Trusting Hashem in Danger

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**Sefer:** HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 8 (ביטחון — Bitachon and Reliance) — Part 4 **This Week:** The Transition from Theory to Practice · The Ten Categories of Bitachon · Two Prerequisites · Category One — Bitachon in Serious (Life-Threatening) Danger

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## Recap from Parts 1–3

### The Definition

**Bitachon** = complete reliance on Hakadosh Baruch Hu, the Creator of all, to whose will everything is subservient. Living this brings **security and serenity** (*betach*). We use the intermediaries Hashem created — but place no *reliance* on them.

### The Three Categories of Bitachon

| Category | Who | Verdict |
|---|---|---|
| **1** | Prophets/exceptional individuals who divested from natural means **by divine instruction** | Not the norm |
| **2** | Deniers of providence (Aristotle) / outward affirmers who inwardly trust intermediaries | Wrong |
| **3** | The *Yirei Hashem* — recognize Hashem oversees all intermediaries and can change them anytime | The goal |

### Established Last Time

- Category 3 done properly → **no need to go overboard** in hishtadlut — but also **never laziness** (forbidden)
- **Cause and effect is real, not an illusion** (against the Mutakallimun) — but it's **open to change at any moment** by Hashem's will

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## The Turning Point — From Theory to Practice

**ולאחר שהבינות ותפסת את כל הדברים האלה, דע כי הביטחון נחלק לכמה וכמה חלקים** *Now that you've grasped all this [theory], know that bitachon divides into many parts* — regarding what one trusts Hashem *for*, and the outcome sought.

Until now: **theoretical bitachon.** Now: **practical scenarios** — when and how bitachon is actually employed.

### A Caveat on the Difficulty

אך הדברים הללו קשים לביאור, וידיעת סודם בשלמות... נשגבת מבינתנו

**Understanding precisely how to apply bitachon in every scenario is beyond us** — even the prophets couldn't fully grasp God's ways. Asaf said *ואחשבה לדעת זאת, עמל הוא בעיני* ("when I sought to understand this, it was wearying"); Hashem told Moshe *וחנותי את אשר אחון* ("I show favor to whom I show favor"). So Rabbi Avraham offers **general categories and direction**, not an exhaustive system.

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## The Structure — Five (× Two = Ten) Categories

## The Two Master Axes

**Axis 1 — Purpose:** Bitachon is used either

to *avoid harm/danger*, OR — **להרחקת הנזקים**
to *attain a benefit/goal* — **להשגת התועלת**

**Axis 2 — Degree of necessity** of the goal/harm:

essential/critical — **הכרחית**
non-essential but nearly so (important) — **בלתי הכרחית אך כמעט הכרחית**
completely non-essential (a luxury) — **בלתי הכרחית לחלוטין**

## The Five Categories (הביטחון יפיק כוח עשרה דברים)

| # | Category | Physical Example | Spiritual Example |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Avoiding **serious** harm (הרחקת נזק חמור) | Drowning at sea; life-threatening illness | Pressure to convert / abandon faith |
| 2 | Avoiding **non-serious but real** harm | A non-life-threatening but distressing illness | A spiritual discomfort, not critical |
| 3 | Attaining an **essential** benefit (תועלת הכרחית) | Basic bread and water to survive | — |
| 4 | Attaining an **important but non-essential** benefit | General nutrition (fruit, etc.) | — |
| 5 | Attaining a **luxury** (non-essential, non-important) | A pleasant extra | — |

Each of the five **× spiritual or physical = TEN** total. E.g., "avoiding serious harm" can be a *physical* serious harm or a *spiritual* serious harm.

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## Two Prerequisites Before the Categories

## Prerequisite 1 — You Cannot Use Bitachon Without Doing Hashem's Will

**המבוא לביטחון הוא השמיעה בקול השם יתעלה ודבקות בתורתו והישמר מפני מרידה** *The gateway to bitachon is obeying Hashem, cleaving to His Torah, and guarding against rebellion.*

There is no point claiming bitachon — however sincere — while not observing the mitzvot. **Doing Hashem's will is the alef-bet prerequisite** for trusting in Him and gaining serenity of mind.

### The Supporting Verses (Tehillim)

| Verse | Point |
|---|---|
| **בטח בה' ועשה טוב** | Trust in Hashem — **and do good** (first) |
| **התענג על ה' ויתן לך משאלות לבך** | Delight in Hashem, then He grants your heart's desires |
| **גול על ה' דרכך ובטח עליו והוא יעשה** | Cast your way on Hashem — but do the mitzvot |
| **קוה אל ה' ושמור דרכו** | Hope in Hashem — **and guard His way** |
| **ותשועת צדיקים מה'... ויושיעם כי חסו בו** | He saves them *because they took refuge in Him* (and did His will) |

### Yirmiyahu's Castigation

**אל תבטחו לכם על דברי השקר לאמר: היכל ה' היכל ה' היכל ה' המה**

Don't trust the falsehood of "the Temple, the Temple, the Temple" — i.e., *I'll do the three pilgrimages (Pesach, Shavuot, Sukkot) and bring sacrifices, then do as I please all year.* It doesn't work that way:

> **הגנוב, רצוח, ונאוף... ובאתם ועמדתם לפני?** *Can you steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely, serve idols — then come stand before Me [in the Temple]?*

Only **כי אם היטיב תיטיבו את דרכיכם** — *if you genuinely improve your ways* — will Hashem dwell with you.

**This is the obvious-but-essential reminder: there's no practical bitachon without fulfilling Hashem's will.**

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## Prerequisite 2 — Spiritual Bitachon Is Always More "Employable" Than Physical

**כל ביטחון שתכליתו דתית הרי הוא נכון ושלם מן הביטחון שתכליתו גשמית** **Bitachon for a spiritual purpose is more valid and complete than for a physical purpose** — **even** bitachon for a *non-essential* spiritual matter outranks bitachon for an *essential* physical matter.

### The Logic

It makes more sense to employ bitachon **to fulfill Hashem's will** than to employ it for Hashem to fulfill *your* will. Physical bitachon is *for me* — my body, myself. Spiritual bitachon is *for the will of Hashem* — so even a non-critical spiritual aim trumps a critical physical one.

### The Analogy — Two People of Bitachon

| Person | What They Trust For | Purpose | Verdict |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Person 1** | Basic survival — bread, clothing, shelter | Purely **mundane** — not to die of hunger/cold, not to beg charity. *Not* in order to serve Hashem or learn Torah | Valid, but lower |
| **Person 2** | **Wealth and authority** (non-essential) | **Spiritual** — to give tzedakah, sustain the needy and Torah-scholars (like **Ovadiah**, who hid and fed 100 prophets from Izevel); to use power to restrain the wicked, protect the oppressed, establish justice | **More valid and complete** (יותר נכון ויותר שלם) |

*(We don't judge Person 1 — someone who can't make ends meet, simply trusting Hashem for food, is in a hard place. But it's not the same level.) (Person 2's intent must be genuine — "you can fool yourself, but you can't fool Hashem.")*

### The Highest Form — Essential AND Spiritual: Yaakov's Bitachon

**אם יהיה אלהים עמדי ושמרני בדרך הזה... ונתן לי לחם לאכל ובגד ללבש... ושבתי בשלום אל בית אבי**

Yaakov asked for food, clothing, and safe return — **all essential** — and his purpose was **והיה ה' לי לאלהים** (*"that Hashem be my God"*): so he could be **free to serve Hashem** undistracted by material struggle. **Essential + spiritual = the most praiseworthy bitachon of all.**

### The Practical Takeaway — Reframing Changes Everything

A sick person praying *"Hashem, heal me so I won't suffer pain"* → bitachon for a **mundane** matter. The same person praying *"Hashem, heal me so I can keep going to shul, helping the poor, serving You"* → transformed into **spiritual** bitachon.

**The shift in focus changes the entire quality of the bitachon.** This is why focus matters when employing it.

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## CATEGORY ONE — Bitachon in Serious (Life-Threatening) Danger

**הראשון בהם הוא הרחקת נזק חמור** *.The first is averting serious harm*

### What Counts as "Serious Harm"

- A **life-threatening illness** (חולאים הקשים)
- **Sudden dangers** (סכנות מקריות) — accident, attack
- War / civil war; falling into **quicksand** (טיט היון); storms, thunder (סופות רעמים); **earthquakes** (רעידת אדמה) — natural forces beyond one's control

These are **critical, death-involved, uncontrollable** situations, for the sake of survival (a mundane purpose).

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## The Method — How to Employ Bitachon Here

### Step 1 — Turn Your Heart to Hashem

**שיתלה האדם את לבו בשם יתעלה, ויפתח בו שירחיק ממנו את הנזק ויצילו מן הפגעים — כי כל הסיבות כפופות לחפצו ורצונו** Cast your heart on Hashem, trusting He will remove the danger and save you — for **all causes are subject to His will.**

### Step 2 — Recall Hashem's Promises Through Tehillim

**Tehillim 91 (יושב בסתר עליון)** — the "song against perils":

- *(Said Shabbat morning, Motzaei Shabbat, and at a levaya — to protect against the spiritual dangers of the soul's ascent.)*
- **Opening** (the structure of trust): **אמר לה' מחסי ומצודתי, אלהי אבטח בו** — "I say to Hashem: my refuge and fortress, my God in whom I trust"
- **Middle**: **כי אתה ה' מחסי, עליון שמת מעונך** — "You, Hashem, are my refuge"
- **End** (the *reason*): **כי בי חשק ואפלטהו, אשגבהו כי ידע שמי** — "Because he desired Me I will rescue him… because he knows My name" — i.e., a **relationship, a brit** with Hashem

**Tehillim 18** (David's song when saved from Shaul):

- **Opening** (his love and trust): **ארחמך ה' חזקי, ה' סלעי ומצודתי ומפלטי, צורי אחסה בו**
- **Middle** (*why* he was saved — his righteousness): **כי שמרתי דרכי ה'… כל משפטיו לנגדי… ואהי תמים עמו** — Hashem saved him *because he kept Hashem's ways*

**How Tehillim actually works:** NOT a mystical/magical effect of reciting the words — but to **remind ourselves who truly governs the world** and to **reset our priorities.** When anxious, open 91, read it (even in English), understand it. *(Anxiety often stems from a lack of bitachon; bitachon can help overcome it — though this is not to say every anxiety sufferer lacks bitachon, nor a substitute for treating genuine medical conditions.)*

### Step 3 — Pray (Tefillah)

**צריך הבוטח לחזק בטחונו על ידי תפילה ובקשה ותחינה**

| Verse | Point |
|---|---|
| **מהולל אקרא ה' ומן אויבי אִוָּשֵׁעַ** | "I call to Hashem… and am saved from my enemies" |
| **בצר לי אקרא ה'… ישמע מהיכלו קולי** | "In my distress I call to Hashem… He hears my voice" |
| **כי מי גוי גדול אשר לו אלהים קרובים אליו** | What nation has God so near, *whenever we call* — we are privileged to speak to Hashem |
| **כי תבא מלחמה… והרעתם בחצצרות ונזכרתם… ונושעתם** | At war, blow the trumpets, be remembered before Hashem, and be saved |

### Step 4 — STILL Employ Every Natural Means

**מכל מקום ברי כי לשם הרחקת הפגעים הרעים, יש להשתמש באמצעים שתיקן השם יתעלה להרחקתם Nonetheless — to avert harm, one must use the means Hashem established for averting it.**

A sick person must **find the best doctor** (within reason), follow **the best diet** (within reason — not at the expense of Shabbat meals, etc.) — *together with* the trust and prayer above.

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## The Torah's Own Proofs — Trust AND Act

Even though Hashem is the ultimate cause, the Torah itself commands natural action:

| Hashem's Role (verse) | Yet the Torah Commands |
|---|---|
| "I bring death and life" — **אני אמית ואחיה** | build a parapet so no one falls (Ki — **ועשית מעקה לגגך** Teitzei) |
| "I wound and I heal" — **מחצתי ואני ארפא** | a doctor shall heal (the license to practice — **ורפא ירפא** medicine) |
| The Kohen anointed for war says **אל ירך לבבכם... אל תיראו** — trust Hashem, say Shema | Yet **ופקדו שרי צבאות בראש העם** — appoint generals; **ובנית מצור** — build siege-works (employ war tactics) |
| not by their sword did" — **כי לא בחרבם ירשו ארץ** they inherit the land" (Bnei Korach) | Yet **ויכהו ישראל לפי חרב** — Israel struck Sichon by the sword |

**The resolution:** *"Not by their sword"* means they didn't **rely on the sword alone** — they relied on Hashem's providence (**כי ימינך וזרועך ואור פניך, כי רציתם**) *while* wielding it. **Build balconies, use doctors, raise armies, wield swords — but know the outcome is from Hashem.**

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## The Snakebite / Cancer Paradigm

if a scorpion stings or a snake bites you (or, *bar minan*, a sudden — **אם קצצך עקרב או הכישך נחש** :cancer diagnosis)

don't *only* lance the wound and take the antidote — **לא רק תסרוט את מקום הנשיכה ותגום תריאק** (do that, certainly!)

but also trust in the One in whose hand is all life — **אלא עליך לבטוח במי שבידו נפש כל חי**

**While taking the medicine / undergoing the ובתוך כדי שתיית הצרי ולקיחת התרופה — תבטח בה' .procedure — trust in Hashem** that healing comes from Him

This does **not** diminish appreciation for the doctors and medicines — on the contrary, it should **increase** our recognition of how wondrously Hashem created these means.

### The Yehi Ratzon Over Medicine (Gemara Berachot, codified in Shulchan Aruch)

*May it be Your will, Hashem, that this engagement"* **יהי רצון מלפניך ה' אלהי שיהא עסק זה לי לרפואה** *be for my healing." (Rabbi Kada: rarely seen practiced today — seemingly forgotten.)* It **connects .the physical act to the recognition that healing comes from Hashem**

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## When There Are No Means Left — Pure Bitachon

if you reach a place with no remedy (bitten in the desert — **אם תקרה למקום שלא תמצא בו דבר מרפא** :with no antidote; ill with no hospital) then **only bitachon** — **אז לא נשאר עליך אלא ביטחון בלבד** **.remains**

### The Sailor in the Storm

מי שהפליג ללב ים, וזעף עליו הים, ונתקו פרשיו, ואבדה עצת מנהיגי הספינה וקברניטיה — **לא נשאר אלא ביטחון בלבד**

The sails are torn, the sailors and captain are at a loss (a "Titanic" scenario) — only bitachon remains. **Hashem knows the magnitude of the danger and, in His mercy, can save where all hope is lost** — as He saved **Chananyah, Mishael, and Azaryah** from the furnace, and **Daniel** from the lions' den, *biskhut godel tzidkatam* (in the merit of their great righteousness): **אלהי שלח מלאכה וסגר פום אריותא**.

**A sobering note:** Rabbi Avraham's own uncle, **Rabbi David (the Rambam's brother), died at sea** — and the Rambam grieved deeply for years. **So bitachon does not always "work" as hoped.** Why? — the next paragraph.

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## Why the Righteous Sometimes Are Not Saved

**ויש עוונות מסתירים ומעכבים חסדו של אלהים** — there are sins that conceal and block God's kindness; or **טעם כמוס** — a hidden reason beyond human grasp.

So **ויבא הדבר שהוא ירא ממנו** — the very thing one feared (and trusted Hashem to prevent) sometimes happens.

### The Examples

- The **Ten Harugei Malchut** (the ten martyrs, read on Tisha B'Av) — killed by wicked Romans
- **Uriah** killed by Yehoyakim; **Zechariah** killed by Yoash (whose own father had saved Yoash); other prophets killed by wicked Israelites

**אין סיבת הדבר קוצר יד ההשגחה** — it is **not** because Hashem is unable to save — **אלא סיבות נסתרות בחכמתו** — but hidden reasons in His wisdom, judgments beyond human comprehension.

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## The Gemara Story — Lulianus and Pappos (Turianus/Trajan)

The wicked Roman ruler **Turianus** seized two righteous Jews (Lulianus and Pappos) and taunted:

*"If you are the people of Chananyah, Mishael, and Azaryah — let your God save you from my hand as He saved them from Nebuchadnezzar!"*

They answered:

חנניה מישאל ועזריה צדיקים גמורים היו, ונבוכדנצר מלך הגון היה וראוי לעשות נס על ידו — **ואנו נתחייבנו הריגה למקום** — *"They were perfectly righteous and Nebuchadnezzar was a worthy king for a miracle. But WE have been found liable for death by Heaven. If you don't kill us, Heaven has many other agents. Hashem has merely handed us to YOUR hand — to exact our blood from you."*

### Two Versions of the Ending

- **Our Gemara**: He killed them — but then **officials came from Rome and killed Turianus** (his brain was crushed).
- **The Be'er Avraham's text**: reads that they **were saved in their merit** (שבזכותן ניצולו) — evidently he had a different girsa.

The depth here: their **knowledge of providence**, their **acceptance of Heaven's judgment**, and a **kiddush Hashem they were not even commanded to make.**

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## A Note on Enemies (Quick Halachic Aside)

When enemies seek your life:

| Enemy | When Not Imminently Pursuing | Reasoning |
|---|---|---|
| **Non-Jewish enemy** sworn to kill you | **Strike first** if you have the ability (כמו בימי דוד) — combine bitachon with military action | *(Applied: Israel's neighbors sworn to its destruction — 100% permitted to act first)* |
| **Jewish enemy** not actively pursuing | **Do NOT attack** — trust Hashem, escape elsewhere | Like **David**, who twice caught Shaul and spared him |

*(When someone breaks in actively threatening your life — **בא במחתרת** — you may kill even a Jewish pursuer to save yourself. The above is about non-imminent enemies.)*

### The Sage's Answer (Tehillim 37)

Asked whether to get informers/slanderers killed:

> **דום לה' והתחולל לו** — read homiletically: be silent before Hashem, and He will make them into **חללים** (corpses); **השכם והערב עליהם בבית המדרש והם כלין מאליהם** — pray morning and evening, and they will perish on their own.

### Spiritual Enemies — Different Rules

For those who **endanger the faith** — *machtiei harabim* (those who cause the masses to sin), *mosrim* (informers), *apikorsim* (heretics) publicly desecrating Hashem's name — **דינם כדין הגויים**; whoever can eliminate them is praiseworthy (in eras when this applied).

- **If you lack the ability** (e.g., in exile, under hostile government): **only bitachon remains** — pray, and tolerate the situation (יסבול את מצב הדחוק).
- **The Chazon Ish**: *nowadays* we don't act against heretics — that was for eras when Hashem's providence was more revealed.
- **Rav Kook**: today the only way to draw them back is **with love.**

### The Beautiful Gemara — Bruria and Rabbi Meir

Rabbi Meir was tormented by *biryonei* (lawless bandits) in his neighborhood and **prayed for them to die.** His wife **Bruria** challenged him:

> **מי כתיב "יתמו חוטאים"? "חטאים" כתיב!** Does it say "may *sinners* be consumed"? It says — **ורשעים עוד אינם**: "**sins**"! Look at the verse's end — "and the wicked are no more" — *because they will have repented*. **אלא בעי רחמי עלייהו דלהדרי בתיובתא** — **pray for them to do teshuvah** (so the wicked are "no more").

Rabbi Meir prayed for their repentance — **and they repented.** *A model of true yirat shamayim.*

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## Summary

## The Framework

- Bitachon now moves **from theory to practice** — but precise application in all scenarios is beyond full human grasp; we work in **general categories**
- **Five categories** (avoid serious harm / avoid lesser harm / attain essential / attain important / attain luxury) **× physical or spiritual = TEN**

## Two Prerequisites

1. **No bitachon without doing Hashem's will** (against Yirmiyahu's "Heichal Hashem" falsehood)
2. **Spiritual bitachon always outranks physical** — even non-essential spiritual over essential physical; Yaakov's (essential + spiritual) is the highest; **reframing a request from mundane to spiritual transforms its quality**

## Category One — Serious Danger

1. **Turn your heart to Hashem** (all causes are subject to His will)
2. **Recall His promises** through Tehillim 91 and 18 — to *reset priorities*, not as magic
3. **Pray** (tefillah, tachanun)
4. **Use every natural means** — best doctor, diet, tactics — the Torah itself commands parapets, doctors, armies, swords, *while* trusting Hashem
5. The **Yehi Ratzon** over medicine connects the act to Hashem
6. When **no means remain** — pure bitachon (Chananyah/Mishael/Azaryah; Daniel) — though **it doesn't always "work"** (the Rambam's brother at sea; the martyrs), for **hidden reasons** beyond human grasp (Lulianus & Pappos)
7. **Enemies**: strike first against a non-Jewish enemy if able; spare a non-pursuing Jewish enemy; for spiritual enemies, act only where able and where they can't be returned — otherwise pray (Bruria: pray for the *sins* to end, not the sinners)

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## Coming Up Next Week

- When may one **rely on miracles** (the final aspect of Category One)?
- **Spiritual** serious danger (Category One, spiritual side)
- Then **Category Two** — bitachon for important-but-non-critical matters

*(Schedule: Rambam tomorrow evening — thrones; Hilchot Shabbat Thursday — new chapter. Aiming to finish Perek 8 before Tisha B'Av.)*

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*B'Ezrat Hashem*

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